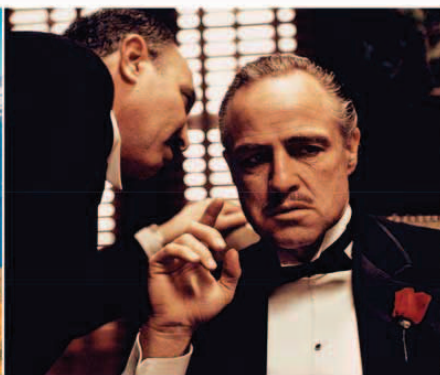




“

We can't help identifying with the protagonist. It's coded in our movie-going DNA.

Roger Ebert

”

trinkets at Montparnasse train station station, the youthful medium was given a nickname that still fits today: the “Seventh Art,” after architecture, painting, music, sculpture, dance, and poetry. Its author was Ricciotto Canudo, an Italian scholar. To Canudo, the power of the movies was that they brought each of the great art forms of the past together into one—to watch movies was to experience all six of the older art forms at once.

Movies evolve

So many years later, the sheer sensory rush of the movies is still enough to overwhelm the audience, in the very best sense of the word. It's hard to imagine the creak and crackle of cinema's early years

drawing a viewer into the screen the way a movie does now—but as the Lumières' train movie shows, movies could make audiences take them as real from the start.

Charting how the movies have evolved as an art form is one of the great joys of being a movie lover. Sometimes the advances may be obvious: the momentous lurches from silence to sound, and from black and white to color. Elsewhere, the revolutions were subtler, as the crafts of filmmaking—cinematography, editing—took on lives of their own.

The wider historical context in which movies were made also needs to be considered—when you talk about movies, you're never *just* talking about movies. Once you dive into the history of movies, you can't help dealing with history in general. Look at the last century of movies and you see real life running through it like the rings of a tree. Purely as cinema, it is hard to overstate the impact of Godzilla, the movie monster who terrorized Tokyo Bay in 1954—and what was

Godzilla but Japan's nuclear trauma made scaly flesh? You don't need to be a movie lover to quote a line from *Some Like It Hot* (“Nobody's perfect!”)—but how different a movie would it have been had its Austrian-born director, Billy Wilder, not been forced, like so many other European filmmakers, to flee to the US as the Nazis took power? The Russian Revolution, the Cold War, the hippie era, feminism, the computer age—every major moment in world history is up there on screen somewhere.

All this in a medium that began in the fairground, one step from the circus, and has spent much of its existence as an excuse for young couples to sit together in the dark. That what was happening on the screen ascended to such glorious entertainment was unlikely enough. That it became art is perhaps even more extraordinary.

A communal experience

In many ways, it is their contradictions that make the movies what they are. How else

“If we're looking for a shark, we're not gonna find him on the land.”

Hooper / Jaws